The Story of a Besieged Town

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An old friend gave me an interesting new topic to investigate.

She claimed that somewhere in the far East, lies a hidden, ancient land, where works of fine fabrics and porcelain are created with staggering beauty.

The opportunity to explore this land is simply too valuable to pass up.

In the dead of night, in the overgrown places far from the crowds. Faint rustling sounds spring from out-of-sight places, where rodents scurry and snakes chase close behind.

Every city has its outskirts.

And today, a curious visitor has arrived in one such place.

Drifting in the air, too slender to be a bird yet too broad to be a butterfly, trembling, wavering up and down.

Pandora Wilson: *coughs*

Pandora Wilson: The letter has gotten damp ... that's sure to affect the way it carries my voice.

Pandora Wilson: But I won't let it affect the interview ... And we don't have more paper to spare.

The snow-white letter bears a dried watermark. A mouth transferring her voice. To any observer, it would appear it was talking to itself.

Pandora Wilson: In any case, a trip like this is certain to be worthwhile. Things here are much different from the West. There are whole new art forms to be discovered and reported.

Pandora Wilson: The dimensions, the fragrance note, the exhibition site, and the medium are all a great unknown to us. It's ... intriguing, to say the least.

But her thoughts are interrupted by movement in the distance.

Pandora Wilson: ... Hm?

Pandora Wilson: The growing tremors soon eclipse all other considerations, as the grass and trees begin to shiver, causing a shower of leaves to fall.

Then comes a clattering sound, intense and rhythmic, followed by a mix of whinnies.

Pandora Wilson: What could that be, beasts or birds? No, it wouldn't be anything so dramatic—

A whirlwind extinguishes her speculation. Feathers flutter and an immense shadow looms.

The sudden downdraft blows the letter over. As it falls, a gentle man's voice pierces the night.

???: Apologies, I did not intend to knock you over.

The gale ceases. Soft feathers gently reach for the letter, propping it upright.

The creature has a human face, but in place of his "hands" are a pair of large feathered wings, and below them ... sharp talons. He is a "birdman."

Pandora Wilson: You're a ... cri- ... No, you can't be a critter. Are you an arcanist from the East?

Pandora Wilson: So, there are bird-like humanoids in the East ...

Words fail her, but her hunches never did. She is entirely sure of what she has seen.

Pandora Wilson: A perfect chance for an interview ... I'll need a drop of "Miracle Conversation" Potion. It helps us understand each other.

The "birdman" tilts his head slightly.

Having the same thought as the letter, he lowers his head and pulls out a bone flute that has been hidden among the feathery tufts on the inside of his wings.

Getian: The tip of the bone flute traces a strange symbol into the air, and the familiar glow of an arcane skill appears with it.

???: You are an object with neither bones nor form ...

The syllables the bird speaks are completely unfamiliar to her, yet she understands them clearly.

It is incredible, almost unimaginable.

???: Now we can communicate.

Pandora Wilson: This must be a new Arcane Skill from the East, one that allows us to understand each other's language.

Pandora Wilson: Great, then I don't need to use this potion anymore.

Putting away the gleaming vial, the letter circles the bird before stopping in front of him.

A business card matching the letter floats down from the air, landing on his thick feathers.

Pandora Wilson: Hello.

???: ... Hello.

Pandora Wilson: I am Pandora Wilson, interviewer and editor-in-chief for UTTU Magazine.

Pandora Wilson: I have come from a faraway place in the West, to find new things to learn and to give a report on them.

Pandora Wilson: Let's start with the most fundamental question. Sir, what should I call you?

Getian: ... I am Gětiān.

Pandora Wilson: That rings to me like a typical Eastern name.

Pandora Wilson: Yet sir, according to all available evidence I have seen, it seems far from typical for people here to have wings as you do.

Pandora Wilson: In the West, we also have winged humanoids. Only, they were exclusively female. The children of Typhon and Echidna, we called them Harpies.

Pandora Wilson: They were once masters of the wind, until they became messengers of bad news and synonymous with evil.

Getian: ... I am no messenger.

Pandora Wilson: That much is obvious, sir.

The voice lets out a short laugh.

Pandora Wilson: You must, I gather, be a herder of these striped horses ... They're a breed I've never seen before—are you a local here?

Getian: These are not truly horses ... and, no.

Getian: ... I am from the mountains.

Pandora Wilson: A tall mountain? Is it far from here?

Getian: It is.

Pandora Wilson: I see you're alone, except for those horses. I've heard some birds push their young out of the nest to hone their abilities; is this journey part of your "rite of passage?"

Getian: ... No, my family are gone now, they did not push me out.

Striped Horse: *neighs*

The strange horses whinny, running out of patience at their long stop.

Getian: ... I am, otherwise occupied.

Getian: I can see our meeting was not a mere coincidence. If you have any other questions, they must wait until next time.

Pandora Wilson: When and where will this "next time" be?

Pandora Wilson: We'll have to make arrangements, how else can we be sure to meet again?

Gětiān looks towards the restless herd.

Faint cries of birds called out in the distance. He sighs deeply, then spreads his wings and takes flight.

Pandora Wilson: This interview is not over yet, sir—

She is answered by a gust of wind.

The "birdman" arcanist flies off into the distance, with the striped herd following him.

Pandora Wilson: A strange disturbance and a solitary outsider ... It seems something is happening in this town. I arrived just in time.

Pandora Wilson: I have to go and see what sort of story is unfolding here.

The letter floats through the air, following the tracks left by the striped horses, as best it can.

Unfortunately, journalism is her strong suit, not tracking.

Pandora Wilson: They've vanished. Where could they have gone?

Pandora Wilson: Not even a trace of their hoof prints ...

Pandora Wilson: I can sense the use of some Arcane Skill ... Yet the only means of such swift mass displacement I'm aware of are the floppy disks of the St. Pavlov Foundation. Could they have a matching form of technology here in the East?

"Chirp, chirp ... Caw caw ..."

Pandora Wilson: ... That sounds like a very large bird? Perhaps, Mr. Gětiān has returned ...

Pandora Wilson: No, though they are somewhat similar. Mr. Gětiān has a longer neck, and he isn't so round ...

Zhuye the Monster: Chirp! Caw caw caw!!!!

Pandora Wilson: —! Wait, don't—

The stench of alcohol washes over her. Obviously not all "birds" have the same sense of manners.

Outside a tavern, two slightly tipsy locals walk through the street.

Citizen I: Oh—what's that racket, did someone break something?

Citizen II: Sounds like it's coming from Jiǔ Niángzǐ's tavern ...?

Citizen II: Ah, it's likely some Zhúyè troublemakers sneaking in for another drink.

Citizen II: Last time, they pushed a jar of goldfish into a liquor jar—what a shock that was for Jiǔ Niángzǐ when she found it in the morning!

Citizen I: We really should let her know.

Citizen I: These Zhúyè are troublesome little things. She'll have to make the fence even higher next time.

Citizen I: They can't be allowed to ruin all that good liquor!

They look at one another, nodding their heads in unison, and begin calling out loudly and knocking on the door.

Citizen II: Jiǔ Niángzǐ! Jiǔ Niángzǐ!

Citizen I: The Zhúyè are wreaking havoc in your tavern again!

On Eastern Wands

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???: Shoo, shoo, shoo—what a mess these Zhúyè have made again!

Thumping stomps and a feather duster whipping the air mixed roughly with a chorus of caws.

Citizen II: Ah! Shoo! Shoo! Begone—begone! Good, we've sent them flying.

Citizen I: This fence will not be enough to keep them out anymore, you ought to raise it higher ...

The voices, sometimes distant, sometimes near, were indistinct and fragmented.

???: Of course. Thank you ... Oh, next time ... Of course, of course—

Words of thanks, farewells, and the sound of a door locking are followed by footsteps.

The owner of the tavern returns to the messy courtyard alone, complaining to herself as she tidies up the overturned liquor jars.

Unaware of her guest, who has been hidden in the mess.

Pandora Wilson: ... Some people would call me lucky, to be soaked through with liquor ... But I never cared for drinking.

???: Huh?

???: Did this jar of liquor just ... Speak?

The footsteps grow closer, then halt. The tilted liquor jar straightens and returns to its place.

Gush—The liquor spills out, and a rush of cool air chills the soaked paper, and brings to its vision a moonlit place with flickering candles and a puzzled face.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh dear! Another letter from those scholars! And it's gotten soaked in this liquor! What a waste ...

The black-haired girl exclaims to herself, as she fishes out the letter from the liquor jar.

Pandora Wilson: Hold on, I'm not just some letter!

Jiu Niangzi: So it's a letter that talks? Ah! Talking paper ... this must be the work of Mr. Wú.

Jiu Niangzi: That red paper lotus flower he gave me for my birthday sang for four days before it finally stopped!

Jiu Niangzi: I told him to stop sending things like this, they just make my head hurt—!

Pandora Wilson: Let me—go. Hey—!

Jiu Niangzi: It must have been damaged, I can't understand what it's saying. What on earth did he write?

Jiu Niangzi: Never mind. Despite the annoyance, it would be wrong to throw it away ...

The communication arcane skill cast by the "birdman" has obviously dissipated. Their words are unintelligible to one another.

The girl's hands move quickly as she mutters to herself. She sticks a grain of rice to the letter and smooths it out against the wall.

Pandora Wilson: —!

This is the perfect opportunity. The letter struggles out of her grip, regaining its freedom.

A small bottle of golden liquid swiftly opened. And a drop of potion falls onto the paper, absorbing instantaneously.

Pandora Wilson: Is this—how you treat—guests? Miss—!

Jiu Niangzi: Ah! Why ... Why is the letter struggling like this?!

Jiu Niangzi: So ... fierce ... I wonder which scholar could have sent you? If only I knew what you were saying ...

The paper shakes itself forcefully, matching Jiǔ Niángzǐ's dumbfounded stare. Certainly, a poem of love wouldn't behave like this.

Her wall is covered with love poems, all their meanings are quite clear. The letter scoffs coldly.

Pandora Wilson: "By the jade palace in spring, selling liquor in the shop. I wish to be joined with my love. Does she know how I long for her?"

Pandora Wilson: Hmph ... Simplistic, vulgar, dull, clichéd.

Pandora Wilson: I'm nothing like this trite, sycophantic rubbish—

Jiu Niangzi: Ah ... So you're not another love-struck scholar's letter?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ blinks and leans in for a closer look.

Jiu Niangzi: Sure enough ... Your paper is different, and your ink is too. You have a different smell, and your writing is ... well it's very different indeed. So, not from a scholar, after all.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, I ... Ms. Mouth? I am very sorry, I mistook you for something else.

The girl hunches over, clasping her hands together as she offers her apologies.

Jiu Niangzi: I'm going to get this rice paste off you. It's gotten all over your back ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ moves closer to the paper, observing it carefully.

But the paste is stuck firmly, so that despite her efforts, she can't remove it.

Jiu Niangzi: Umm ...

Pandora Wilson: ...

Jiu Niangzi: ... Ms. Mouth, please let me wipe you clean.

She is sorry about her recklessness.

Pandora Wilson: With that dirty, dripping rag you're holding?

The letter rejects her offer "viciously."

Pandora Wilson: I suggest you stop now, before you make things any worse.

This is going to be a very special interview.

The mouth takes a deep breath, trying to ignore the awkward stickiness that now permeated the paper.

Pandora Wilson: How about we start with where these letters came from?

Pandora Wilson: Most of them seem packed with useless words, lacking in any originality. Even at their most sincere, it's all superficial, unable to achieve anything more than empty flattery.

Pandora Wilson: These hardly seem like treasures worth keeping. They may be poems in the technical sense, but they're far from art.

Pandora Wilson: So, why would you collect them?

Jiu Niangzi: You don't think of them as art ...?

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Mouth, truthfully, I don't understand much about art or collecting. It all seems like something rich gentlemen enjoy doing ... Gathering words or paintings and locking them away in a room.

Jiu Niangzi: But these poems were all written for me. So, naturally, I kept them.

Pandora Wilson: I suppose collecting personal letters could be called a hobby, if nothing else.

Pandora Wilson: I once knew a beautiful actress who hired out an entire office just to store all the love letters she received from her admirers. She said the letters always made her feel better in times of pain and stress.

Pandora Wilson: So ... do you enjoy reading these letters? Perhaps, reading all their flattery gives you a bit of vain pleasure.

Glancing from the letters on the wall to the talking letter in front of her, Jiǔ Niángzǐ smiles knowingly.

Jiu Niangzi: Haha, you've got it all wrong, miss. I don't even know what these letters say ... I can't read.

Pandora Wilson: So you ...?

Jiu Niangzi: As far as I know, these are just thank you letters.

Jiu Niangzi: Of course, some letters could be praising my excellent liquor. I heard a scholar read one to me. It was all about "intoxicating this, intoxicating that" ...

Jiu Niangzi: I'm glad so many people enjoy my liquor, when I get to serve them, I feel as if I'm a Xiángruì descending to bless the masses!

Pandora Wilson: "Xiángruì" ...? I've never heard this word before. What does it mean?

Jiu Niangzi: It's a long story, miss. Here, let's take a seat—

Jiǔ Niángzǐ sits on the veranda, spreads out the hem of her coat, and lays the letter on her lap.

Hesitating at first, she strokes the back of the paper, attempting to gently remove the sticky globs of rice.

Jiu Niangzi: "Xiángruì" is an auspicious sign ... They bring good luck whenever they appear.

Jiu Niangzi: Some are horses, some are deer, some are turtles, and others birds ...

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Mouth, you can also be a Xiángruì, if you bring good luck to others!

Jiu Niangzi: Then everyone would be clamoring to write to you and profess their love for you and even pray to you for their good fortune!

Pandora Wilson: For ease of communication, am I right to understand that these "Xiángruì" are a type of non-human Arcanists, or Arcane animals?

The paper unfolds. The words appear on its inner layer.

Pandora Wilson: There are people here that write letters to Arcanists and pray to them for good luck ... Even venerating and exalting them like gods or spirits ...

Pandora Wilson: I never imagined it would be like this in the East.

Jiu Niangzi: The East? ... Ms. Mouth, are you from the West?

Pandora Wilson: Yes, I am from the West, a land far from here.

Pandora Wilson: I came here to investigate a new kind of art that has emerged in this land and to showcase it.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, I've heard of this. I know a scholar who writes this kind of thing—he says it's, it's—a local chronicle!

Jiu Niangzi: It's a book that specifically records the customs, traditions, and geography of a place. If someone reads this book, even without leaving home, they might come to learn about interesting things that are happening miles away!

Pandora Wilson: ...

The red lips on the paper twitch slightly.

Pandora Wilson: Indeed, my publication is a sort of "local chronicle." You're quite right.

Pandora Wilson: Most of our readers are on the other side of the world, in the West.

Pandora Wilson: There was also a period of Arcane mania there, when people exalted Arcanists and relied on their divination and guidance.

Pandora Wilson: But that's in the distant past, and Arcanist culture has been on a downward spiral since the witch hunts.

Pandora Wilson: Now, they've taken to the stage once more, but much of what they do is still behind the scenes. On the one hand, they have been thoroughly integrated into our scientific understanding of nature. But they've also been stripped of the mystery of the Arcane, so they're no longer revered. They're neither above nor below humans, a kind of neutral state.

Jiu Niangzi: Are you saying that the West has no more faith? Do you not have deities or temples?

Pandora Wilson: No, many still have faith, but faith is faith. In the West, Humans and Arcanists often revere different gods.

Jiu Niangzi: Does it need to be so divided?

The girl's face wrinkles, her nose twitching slightly. She looks like she is thinking hard.

Jiu Niangzi: A god is a god. As long as they give out their blessings, isn't that enough to believe in?

Pandora Wilson: That might be so, miss.

The paper gently pats her, wiping the grimace away.
Then it rises gracefully, drifting back and forth through the courtyard, as the voice murmurs to herself.

Pandora Wilson: However, some sort of difference does exist.

Pandora Wilson: Though a Human and an Arcanist might appear similar, there is indeed a gap in their underlying essence.

Pandora Wilson: It's like the difference between ceramics and fiberglass, or silk and cotton.

Jiu Niangzi: So why does this difference exist? And when did it start to exist?

Pandora Wilson looks at Jiǔ Niángzǐ. She blinks her eyes in response, with round pupils like dark purple grapes.

Jiu Niangzi: ...

Pandora Wilson: What do you think about this question?

Jiu Niangzi: ... Me?

Jiu Niangzi: I'm asking you because I don't understand, Miss Mouth.

She holds her face in an exasperated show of innocence.

Jiu Niangzi: I don't really understand what you're saying. There are many words that you speak that are unfamiliar to me.

Stretching out her fingers, Jiǔ Niángzǐ puts them down one by one with each new thing she says.

Jiu Niangzi: Is fiberglass ... a kind of glass? I do know of silk, but it is a material that only certain officials can wear.

Jiu Niangzi: I haven't even seen many of these things before, let alone compared them.

All ten fingers lay into her palms, turning them into two rounded fists. She flings them forward, lashing out at the night air.

Jiu Niangzi: Miss Mouth, you're different. You aren't me. I've never been anywhere. But you've seen all there is in the West, and now you've come to the East.

Jiu Niangzi: Comparing differences and looking for their cause is something only you can do. That's why I'm asking you!

Pandora Wilson: ... Indeed.

The paper folds itself again. Her voice softened considerably.

Pandora Wilson: You make an excellent point.

Jiu Niangzi: Great! Then I suggest you leave first thing in the morning and take a look around the area. We're in the merchant's hub!

Jiu Niangzi: It can get very lively around here. And even if you don't discover what you're looking for, it may still be good to go out and just have fun! What could be wrong with that?

Jiu Niangzi: Oh—and one more thing!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ stands, patting her now numb knees, and walks towards Pandora Wilson with intent.

Then she delicately takes the paper in her hands.

Jiu Niangzi: It was wrong of me to stick a guest on the wall.

Jiu Niangzi: It was also wrong of me to assume you were a silly love poem.

Her words are true and sincere, and her small, tense face shines in the moonlight—

The corners of the letter have been pulled and are difficult to refold. The sticky rice paste and crumpled paper proved impossible to hide in the moonlight.

Jiu Niangzi: It ... was also wrong of me ... to pick at your paper ...

Pandora Wilson: ...

Pandora Wilson: .....

Jiu Niangzi: So I must humbly offer to cover your accommodation and all expenses during your stay in Pèi City!

Jiu Niangzi: Of course, if you can find the answer to your questions, please tell me ... It would be wonderful to know ...

A Ghost Story Collection

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Pandora Wilson: What a generous girl. One could call her endearing simplicity "cute."

Pandora Wilson: ... As long as that cuteness doesn't get taken out on me.

Pandora Wilson: Anyway, I accepted her offer of hospitality and money. It was only right.

Peddler I: My golden elixirs bring wealth and dispel disaster! Enlighten your mind! Are you after my lucky charms, or miracle remedies?

Peddler II: Come one, come all! Witness this extraordinary lucky cabbage! A superior produce harvested only once every three years near the Wénqǔxīng Temple ...

Peddler I: Face and bone painting, sketches and drawings. Come and see!

The peddler's calls and shouts echo back and forth, with shelves on both sides of the street filled with colorful goods.

Pedestrians dressed in a motley of colors bustle around in an endless stream.

Peddler I: Madam! Madam! Wait a moment!

The peddler's face is painted with a wide, ever-bright smile. A pair of fox ears poke out from his hat, and orange and black fur grow on either side of his cheeks.

Pandora Wilson: I don't need anything.

Peddler I: Oh, but why rush off, madam! It couldn't hurt to take a look, it won't cost you a thing—

The peddler pushes out a small wooden cart festooned with talismans and containers full of pills. But these are not what attract the most attention.

A wooden stick is inserted in the stall, on which a white cloth is suspended, like a waving flag. Three large characters are scrawled in vermilion ink.

Pandora Wilson: ... "Face Painting"?

Peddler I: Yes, madam. Face painting, that is exactly what that is!

Peddler I: Looking at you, I see only lips on your face. Pretty lips, of course, but you have no nose or eyes at all.

Peddler I: And if you have no nose, you must not be able to smell sweet perfumes. And if you have no eyes, you cannot see the beauty of the world. Not to mention ears and eyebrows!

Peddler I: Sounds like a hard life? How could it not be dull?

Pandora Wilson: So, you want to draw the rest of my face for me?

Peddler I: Certainly! I will use a secret skin painting method to paint you, so that you will live a life of elegance and tranquility from now on. You'll be envied by even the immortals!

What is there to be gained from interviewing a businessman? Or rather, what would it cost?

The paper stretches into an approximation of a smile.

Pandora Wilson: ... As it happens, I have some silver with me.

Pandora Wilson: But can your painting technique be trusted?

Peddler I: Of course! My art is a product of generations, a business passed down my family line. I've been painting since I was a child—

Peddler I: Should the painting not be to your satisfaction, come find me and I will fix it for you. Just make sure not to get it wet for seven days after painting ...

He flicks his fluffy ears, and his hat nearly floats off his head.

Peddler I: Oh, enough about that, we'll talk about it later. First, you'll have to choose a style!

Peddler I: Here, take a look. Which one do you want?

The peddler eagerly hands over a picture album, flipping it open to reveal countless eyes of different shapes.

Peddler I: Please take a look. I have all the most current styles!

Peddler I: Of course, this pair at the very top is our bestseller! Everyone loves it!

Pandora Wilson: Best-selling eyes?

A pair of dark, shimmering eyes are drawn on the paper. There are indeed beautiful, but not outstanding.

Pandora Wilson: Are these "best-selling eyes" popular for purely aesthetic reasons, or is there something else?

Peddler I: Haha ... Naturally, take a look at the eyes—delicately shaped, an average length on the top and bottom, and black as ink.

Peddler I: In our profession, these are called "Goose Eyes." Another name for them is "eyes of righteousness."

Peddler I: Goose Eyes not only have a pleasing shape and a good name but also excellent symbolism.

Peddler I: According to physiognomy, if a person has Goose Eyes, they are modest and courteous, have a measured temperament, and will be rich and prosperous.

Peddler I: Miss Mouth, may I say you would look fabulous with Goose Eyes.

Peddler I: Now, about your nose ...

Citizen: Tsk! You itinerant con-man, not surprised to see you still swaggering about!

With a loud shout, the bustling street falls silent for a few seconds. Everyone stares blankly at the newcomer.

The newcomer has a black cloth with two holes in it tied around their head.

One hole is where a person's forehead should be, and the other is on his cheekbone. And two angry red eyes peer out from them.

Citizen: Four days ago, I spent a small fortune on your so-called face painting. And it all seemed fine at first.

Citizen: But now, look at me! It's left my eyes, nose, and mouth all askew!

Citizen: Whenever I go out, I have to cover my face because of you—you owe me an explanation!

He furiously pushes aside the letter, grabs the fox-eared peddler by his clothes and begins to shake him.

The cloth sinks slightly inward in the middle of his face, rising and falling with the sound of each frenzied breath, making it clear that the place where his nose should have been is now his mouth.

Peddler I: This ...!

Peddler I: Oh, sir, this—this is obviously because the paint got wet— that's what ruined everything!

Peddler I: Was I not clear when we made the deal? Hmm? So why are you coming to me with complaints now?!

In their struggle, the peddler's hat flows off, his collar opens, and the contents of the stall are scattered all over the ground.

The peddler's tail stiffens, and his ears press tightly against his scalp, but he can't match the man's strength. He can only shout at the top of his lungs.

Peddler I: You—you're extorting me! Help, help!

Citizen: You aren't conning your way out of this!

Citizen: I ought to teach you a lesson today, you crooked businessman!

As the pair are at loggerheads, an elderly man sweeps aside the crowd and stands between the two.

Lizheng: What has caused all of this commotion?

Lǐzhèng's arrival effects an immediate hushed silence.

Followed soon after by, an even bigger ruckus—as the peddler and the man begin to argue over one another.

Lizheng: Quiet—quiet!

Lǐzhèng examines the man with the crooked mouth and eyes.

Lizheng: State your case.

Citizen: Lǐzhèng, sir, four days ago, I let this crooked businessman paint my face. I only wanted to make myself look a little more presentable, then maybe I wouldn't scare away the ladies ...

Citizen: But then after I washed my face, my entire face went crooked!

Lǐzhèng then looks towards the fox-eared peddler and gestures for him to speak.

Lizheng: Your turn.

Peddler I: Sir, please understand ... To be effective, my miraculous method of face painting requires my clients to go seven days without washing or wetting the paint.

Peddler I: I made this very clear during the transaction. But only four days have passed, and as the man himself said, he has washed his face!

Peddler I: If it did get wet, then his face would return to normal after seven days. As for its current crookedness, there's nothing I can do. He'll just have to cover it up.

The more he says, the more aggravated he feels. The peddler purses his lips.

Lizheng: In that case, the answer is quite simple.

Lizheng: You, sir, must wait for three more days. If your face remains dissatisfactory after three days, then the peddler will have to find some way to restore your previous appearance.

Citizen: Lǐzhèng, sir, you have my greatest admiration. But this deceitful merchant is clearly incompetent, how can I trust his word that my features won't stay distorted?

Citizen: When it comes to casting spells or seeking medical treatment, timing is critical. A day or two is manageable, but if too much time passes, I could be stuck like this forever. I ... I won't be able to live!

The burly man covers his face with his hands and lets out a pitiful whimper.

Citizen: It's bad enough that people think I look like a joke ... But with this face even eating becomes an unbearable hassle!

Citizen: A mouthful of rice winds up either in my eyes or up my nose ... Once I finally get it in my mouth, it makes my head spin all over again ...!

Peddler I: Fine ... Sir, if you don't trust me, let's go and find Ms. Fù.

Peddler I: Ms. Fù's red talismans are renowned throughout the land. She will surely have a solution to our mutual problem. And as lucky would have, we're well-acquainted, she will certainly grant my request ...

Citizen: Ms—Ms. Fù?! You awful fox, you're talking nonsense again!

The man's askew face suddenly flushes, his neck reddening along with it.

Peddler I: Sir, I'm nothing if not an honest businessman. I've never swindled a soul.

Peddler I: Haven't you heard of Hú Fù's Emporium? I've done very good business with Ms. Fù. We wouldn't lie to you about something like this.

Citizen: Hú ... Hú ... Oh! Your last name is Hú—

His eyes widen and blink repeatedly, his crooked mouth opening and closing.

The man stomps his feet, dropping a bag of broken silver. He cries out "Forget it," and turns away hurriedly.

The peddler, who has looked sad just a moment before, smiles. With sharp eyes and nimble fingers, he slips the money bag into his pocket.

Peddler I: Right, with all that finished. Where was that lovely-lipped customer? I can't let all this trouble keep me from making money ...

The excitement dies down, and the crowd of onlookers eventually disperses.

The peddler's ears prick up, and he looks from side to side. At last, he catches sight of the fluttering white sheet. She is already far down the road, followed by Lǐzhèng, who is dressed in green.

Pandora Wilson: You said the Hú and Fù families have been in business together for nearly ten years in this city?

Lizheng: Yes. Though, the story of the Hú and Fù families started a few generations ago.

Lizheng: In the beginning, the Hú family came down from the mountains to the city. They were fox spirits and tricksters. When they saw two adjacent houses that they liked, they decided to move in.

Lizheng: The owner of those houses was a wealthy merchant who would often be away on business during the year. After the Hú moved in, they began to torment his wife and children. It got so bad that they moved out within just three months.

Lizheng: Once the merchant returned, he tried selling the property, but anyone who tried to buy it was quickly driven away by the foxes' tricks. Over time, everyone knew to avoid the houses, so all his buyers dried up.

Pandora Wilson: So the foxes ... No, the Hú family ... just lived there?

Pandora Wilson: Isn't that illegal? Why didn't the city's management intervene?

Lizheng: At the time ...

Lǐzhèng looks up at the sky, pondering for a moment.

Lizheng: Don't laugh, madam, but at that time, the management of Pèi City was very lax. Back then the leaders only cared for themselves and ignored the concerns of the people.

Pandora Wilson: These things happen everywhere. It's hardly surprising.

The paper trembles slightly, returning to the previous topic.

Pandora Wilson: So, did the Fù family take up residence there afterward?

Lizheng: Yes. The Fù family was poor and had only a small straw house to live in. It also happened that the snow was heavy that winter and collapsed the roof of their house.

Lizheng: With no other family around, Mr. Fù and his wife had nowhere to go. In desperation, they decided to brave the haunted houses and its fox spirits.

Lizheng: Mr. Fù was a scholar and didn't make much money. What little he earned was from helping people write letters.

Lizheng: His wife's maiden name was Huò. She was born in Qiántáng and had something to do with Daoism. Her family fell out of power, but a few generations ago, some of them had transformed into immortals.

Lizheng: Unfortunately, she had few useful talents. She could paint, but not well. Her paintings were not worth much.

Pandora Wilson: The Hú family were arcanists. And having lived so long deep in the mountains means their bloodline must have been very pure. Meanwhile, it sounds like the Huò family was much more deeply entrenched in the world, so their bloodline had thinned ... Was she a mixed-blooded arcanist?

Pandora Wilson: So, when the merchant abandoned this home, it turned into a struggle between these Arcanists?

Lǐzhèng waves his hand, revealing a candid smile.

Lizheng: Not quite, madam. Let me explain it to you in detail.

Lizheng: Let's start with the Hú and Huò families. They are pretty much as you said.

Lizheng: The Hú family were originally fox spirits from the mountains, indeed they had their own domain there. Their marriages were restricted to their race. But this particular branch lost its power and land in some kind of squabble, so they were forced to come here to make a living.

Lizheng: The Huò family, on the other hand, had a background in Daoism. They had long intermarried with spirits of plants and trees. But they always lived among humans, and their marriages were more open-minded.

Lizheng: So, as you guessed, one side was the Arcanists, and the other was the Mixed.

Lizheng: But then there was also Mr. Fù in the house, as I mentioned.

Pandora Wilson: And I suspect that he was ...

Lizheng: Yes, he is human.

Lizheng: Mr. Fù's family was poor, and had no particular talents or abilities to speak of. There were no special restrictions on who they could marry, but most were ordinary humans. He was, as countless generations of his ancestors had been, thoroughly human.

Lizheng: As for Mr. Fù and Ms. Huò, they were deeply in love, a marriage as solid as gold; one a careful and smart planner, and the other able to cast spells.
They relied on their wits to contend with the foxes, as they squabbled back and forth.

Lizheng: They had set up a trap for the foxes—to conjure up a green snake that would appear behind one of them. And it worked. It scared the eldest of the Hú family; when he saw that snake, they say, he jumped three feet into the air and fell with a splash into a nearby well.

Pandora Wilson: And then?

Lizheng: Haha, well the couple had heard the commotion. They came shouting and scrambling over the fence between the two houses, in order to rescue the old fox.

Lizheng: Ms. Huò, feeling guilty for endangering someone's life, took her silver hairpin and used the Máoshān Art of Walking Through Walls to tunnel through the earth and reach the bottom of the well to fish out the old fox.

Lizheng: Unfortunately, the old fox still fell ill from all the shock and cold, and Ms. Huò drained by her use of such an unpredictable magic, fell sick as well.

Lizheng: So the Hú and Fù all nursed them back to health together; feeling indebted and grateful to one another, they somehow wound up becoming the closest of friends.

Lizheng: After the two families reconciled, the wildness of the Hú family began to soften, and they learned much more about the world. After a few years, they even took it upon themselves to apologize to the merchant's family.

Pandora Wilson: ...

The story draws to a close. The visitor from the West, thrilled from start to finish, is silent for a while before she asks another question.

Pandora Wilson: And that's how their relationship continues to be to this day?

Lizheng: Indeed it is.

Pandora Wilson: A ... Pure-blooded human—

Pandora Wilson: Closely connected with an Arcanist and a Mixed-blood, almost... As close as family.

Pandora Wilson: Is there no conflict or estrangement between them?

Pandora Wilson: As you said, these Hú were hard to tame and had long plundered the residence. Did nobody care about all of their wrongdoings?

Lizheng: Madam, a certain amount of conflict and injustice will always exist; they are as constant as the movement of the heavens or the falling of rain.

Lǐzhèng halts. They have reached the end of the bustling merchant's hub. Looking back, it is full of merchants and crowds of pedestrians.

Lizheng: The commotion you saw just now happens several times a day in this market.

Lizheng: With mortals, extraordinary men, mountain spirits, and even immortals ascending on their clouds, how could there be no friction or discord among them?

Lizheng: It's said there is friction between the extraordinary and the mundane and animosity between monsters and immortals, and do mortals not war against each other? Do extraordinary men not scheme against one another?

Lizheng: But if it is true that everyone can harm one another, why can't they love each other just as easily?

Pandora Wilson: I understand what you mean.

The writing on the paper has stopped, and the letter refolds itself.

Pandora Wilson: This has truly been an unbelievable story and a rare new display of art.

Pandora Wilson: Thank you for sharing it with me, sir.

Lizheng: Haha ... You're welcome. Jiǔ Niángzǐ told me you were her guest, which makes you our guest. She has welcomed you, and so do we.

Lizheng: I hope you might spend some more time with her. She never had any friends her age ...

Gate Guard: Message!

Gate Guard: Greetings, Lǐzhèng! Mr. Fǎcáo has arrived. We were waiting for you to return to discuss how to deal with the mischievous birdman we seized!

Pandora Wilson: Birdman ...?

Pandora Wilson: What a coincidence. I, too, encountered a "birdman" gentleman not long ago. Lǐzhèng, could you arrange a meeting between us?

Lizheng: Apologies, madam. But Zhící is not a place for idle chit-chat.

Lǐzhèng nods a polite farewell. Walking away with the gate guard, they disappear at the end of the road.

As the letter returns to the merchant's hub, a girl in a green dress rushes past her in a hurry.

Young Girl: Cousin! Cousin, what's going on? Did you get into another argument? Did you pull their tail again?!

Young Girl: I keep saying I should run the stand, but somehow I always let you win. Whenever you get into arguments, you come home shedding fur in patches with an upset stomach. Then we'll all have to listen to you howling through the night—

Critter Geographics

COL-400604

Getian: ...?

There is a faint trembling sound, and a white light appears in the dim space.

A glimmer of silver flashes, accompanied by the jingle of bells, and a round hole suddenly appears on the wall.

Getian: Who—are you?

Pandora Wilson: "Is the Art of Walking Through Walls not marvelous?"

Beneath the paper, a silver hairpin floats gently in front of Gětiān.

Pandora Wilson: Your prediction was correct, Mr. Gětiān. We meet again.

Pandora Wilson: But why are you so surprised? Aren't you able to see the future?

Getian: I do not see the future. Not really ...

Gětiān closes his eyes and the hole in the wall closes.

Getian: My clan is called the "Mièméng." We are able to do Bone Readings and capable of changing fates.

Getian: Your inquiring mind was evident as soon as I read your Features of Bones, and I knew you're not one to give up on your "interviews" easily. I hadn't avoided you on purpose. So it was only a matter of time for us to run into one another again.

Pandora Wilson: What did you mean by "Features of Bones"? Based on what you're saying, it seems to be ... a person's essence?

Getian: You might say that.

Getian: One's bones provide support. Beneath the skin lies flesh and blood; beneath flesh and blood lie tendons and veins. All are housed by the skeleton.

Getian: Beyond these chaotic, soft things, Features of Bones is the root of what we become. Understanding Features of Bones allows one to comprehend all things.

The bird's wide wings folded, and the paper hovers over them.

Pandora Wilson: So, you might say you are also an admirer of beauty.

Pandora Wilson: I admire things through their fragrance note, their medium, their dimensions, and form. But you eschew the rest, and look straight to the structure beneath.

She examines the bird and places the silver hairpin before him.

Pandora Wilson: I happen to have a question that I'd like to discuss with a wise arcanist from the East who understands all things.

Getian: This pin is what allows you to "walk through walls" ...

Pandora Wilson: Yes, it's a fantastic silver hairpin. Roughly crafted but interestingly shaped. It is also lightweight and easy to carry, making it a rare, high-quality wand.

Pandora Wilson: It came from Ms. Huò in the story, Ms. Fu's grandmother. She, in turn, had gotten the silver hairpin from her grandmother.

Pandora Wilson: It is worn by women in their family—mothers, wives, and daughters.

Pandora Wilson: Thanks to intermarriage, it had been worn in the hair of Arcanists and Humans, of pure and of mixed blood.

Pandora Wilson: Some of its owners could use it, and wield its great power to save lives. Some couldn't, and with them it would rest peacefully, serving as only a decoration.

Pandora Wilson: This seems to me to be the essence of the "East," a microcosm of different limitations.

Pandora Wilson: And the "bones" you see in me come from a different "framework" the one that defines the West.

Pandora Wilson: I wonder, what do you think causes these differences between us?

Getian: What you really ask is, why do two trees grow different branches?

Taking the silver hairpin, the tips of the wings cross to lift it up.

Getian: As the famous saying goes here, "Oranges grown south of the Huai River are true oranges; but if they are transplanted north of the river, they become acrid and bitter."

Getian: The same seed, sown in different places, will yield different fruit.

Getian: It may have something to do with the way the seed was sown ... Or maybe with the rain, sun, wind, and dew. All of it is related.

Getian: So why ask such a question? Do you perhaps long to go back in time and correct these two trees as they branch off in different directions?

Pandora Wilson: ... I have no such intention.

Pandora Wilson: I'm just trying to record things as they are and find the answers to my questions.

Getian: You said you were an interviewer.

Getian: Do your interviews seek definitive answers?

Pandora Wilson: No ... Of course not. UTTU is meant to show ideas, thoughts, and the true essence of things.

Pandora Wilson: It is meant to be a showcase, a pioneering consciousness. Not a textbook or a tool.

Getian: That's what I see in you, Ms. Pandora Wilson.

Getian: Focusing on these minutiae will lead you astray.

Gětiān takes a step forward, gently tossing the silver hairpin in his hand ahead of him. With a jingle, the tip of the hairpin strikes the wall squarely.

He has long known the incantation to open the hole.

Getian: "Is the Art of Walking Through Walls not marvelous?"

Light reappears. Ms. Fù, who is waiting with a curious expression outside the walls of Zhící, tugs on her cousin's sleeve and shakes it vigorously.

Young Girl: Ms. Mouth's words really worked. She said she wanted to see the birdman, and her words got him to come out!

Getian: The walls of this place are like a prison. But if you have the skill to penetrate their walls, it is a small matter to escape.

The blank white paper stands beside the hole in the wall, its crimson lips pursed slightly.

Pandora Wilson: Thank you for your wisdom.

[English text unavailable]

COL-400605

Storyteller: Last time we spoke—

Citizen VI: Lùshǔ the Xiángruì came to the human world to go through the god's test, but she repented!

Storyteller: Exactly. She had been troubled by the repentance until the New Year's Eve. That night, her tutor straightened her out, and she was very grateful. After that, she bid him goodbye and went to the broken bridge alone.

Wooden Doll: **Ms. Mouth! Ms. Mouth!**

The candles are dim. The place is clearly deserted.

As the paper floats into the room through the window, a wooden doll eagerly rushes up to it.

Pandora Wilson: Are you ... Ms. Jiǔ's arcane creation?

Wooden Doll: **A message, a message.**

The wooden doll jumps on a piece of paper.

Pandora Wilson: ... I can't believe she couldn't even keep her promise to me.

The tone is mocking, yet intimate. It has only been a few days she has stayed with her, but they have become quite familiar with each other.

The farewell letter left for Pandora is unfolded, with a crude drawing of a person carrying a package on the paper. The figure has a bun on its head with a liquor ladle sticking out from it.

Below the drawing, a few words are written roughly, as if they have been copied from somewhere else.

Pandora Wilson: "Alright," "Xiángruì," "Goodbye"...

Pandora Wilson: It seems like she has found her own way of walking through walls.

The night sky outside the window is bright, and firecrackers ring out—it is a night of celebration.

The streets are filled with a sense of peace and tranquility. Firecracker debris is scattered on the ground, silently indicating the excitement of the previous night.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's tavern is deserted. Its door left wide open, with not a drop of liquor left in any of the jars.

The foreigners hurriedly make their way towards the city gate.

Bessmert: Hm? What's this ...?

Yenisei: What is it, Madam Bessmert?

Bessmert: No, it's nothing. It's just that there is a strange business card in my backpack with Braille engraved on it. It seems to say ... "UTTU"?

Yenisei: What's that?

Bessmert: I'm not sure. Maybe a magazine, or a novel. I feel like I know it from somewhere ... It sounds very familiar to me.

Yenisei: I see. My mother never allowed me to read books for leisure, and after joining this expedition, I really had no time for reading ... I suppose I know nothing about these kinds of things.

Yenisei: Once we get out of here, I'll help you find more information about it. Don't worry.

Bessmert: Thank you, child.

They go far away, and their voices are muffled and inaudible.

The tavern door stands open, and a white letter floats up from the table, shaking off the dust that had settled on it overnight.

Before her lay another sheet of paper. The local chronicle has been completed. The cover depicts a girl with a backpack and bun and a silver hairpin, as if drawn by hand.

Pandora Wilson: Before my old friend knocks on the door of UTTU Magazine—

Pandora Wilson: We obviously have our own business to attend to.